happen. Even before the disappointment of conceding the goal sank in, the thought crossed my mind. *Dave Seaman's going to get hammered for this. If we lose, it will have been me in 1998, Phil in 2000, and Dave in 2002, the same stuff all over again.*

When I'd first joined up with England six years ago, Dave Seaman had been one of the players who actually put himself out to try to make me feel welcome. Ever since, shooting practice against Dave, and the banter that went with it, has been my favorite part of England training sessions. The last person in the world who deserved abuse for us failing against Brazil was Dave Seaman. Right then, in Shizuoka, I wanted to go up and put my arms around him, tell him everything would be all right. It wasn't the time, though. We were 2–1 down to Brazil. There were forty minutes to go.

I don't think many people watching could see us getting back into it. Out there playing, I never really felt like there was an equalizer in us. When Ronaldhino got sent off for launching himself at Danny Mills, you could sense the crowd in the stadium—the England supporters, anyway—were thinking this was our chance: eleven against ten. The extra man actually worked against us. Brazil, with a full team, would never change how they play. Once they were ahead, they kept pushing on, looking for a third goal. While that was happening, at least we knew there was the possibility of another mistake, like Lucio's in the first half, if we could get the ball forward on the break. Once Ronaldhino went, though, they decided to defend and protect the lead. We didn't have enough energy left to force the pace of the game, which was what they were letting us do for the last half an hour. There was no way now we were going to catch them short of players at the back: when they needed to, Brazil proved they could defend with the best of them. Our one half chance, when Teddy, on as a sub, got fouled on the edge of their box, came and went when the ref didn't give the free-kick. A free-kick had seemed like the only way we'd be likely to score since half-time.

Even after I'd watched them go on to turn over Germany in the final, the thought that we'd been knocked out by the world champions, the best team in the tournament by far, wasn't much by way of consolation. I thought we missed out that afternoon on a real chance of winning the World Cup. And so did all the other England players. With all due respect to Brazil, it wasn't like we'd lost the game so much as handed it over; and that was a horrible feeling. We were all down. Devastated. Dave Seaman was standing in the center circle looking like the loneliest man in the world, never mind that he was surrounded by other England players. I went over and put an arm over his shoulder, spoke into his ear, his head bent in towards me.